PREPARING FOR INTIMACY

James 1:17 says, *"Every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, and comes down from the Father of lights, with Whom there is no variation or shadow of turning."* One of God's good and perfect gifts is intimacy in marriage. God created sex. He created it as good, to be enjoyed, to be satisfying, to bring pleasure, to be fulfilling and to produce offspring. God gave sex as a seal of a covenant. Just as Abraham was circumcised when he entered into a covenant with God, so sex between a husband and wife is the seal of their marriage covenant. It's a gift God has given them to give to each other.

God created man and woman with a desire and physical attraction for each other. Within marriage, that desire and attraction can be and should be expressed to the fullest. I Corinthians 7:3 says, *"Let the husband render to his wife the affection due her, and likewise also the wife to her husband."* The desires that God had put within us can only be truly fulfilled and satisfied within the confines of marriage.

As you'll notice, the sexual relationship has been qualified as being within the confines and covenant of marriage - that is, because sex outside of marriage is sin. Premarital sex, fornication, and adultery are all perversions or counterfeits of God's gift. People always have what they think are good reasons or excuses for sex outside of marriage, but it all boils down to one thing - it's sin!

We know from the Word that God blesses and the devil curses. Proverbs, chapter 5 gives the contrast between satan's way and God's way when it comes to sexual relationships. Verses 1-14 describes what fruit comes from immorality: bitterness, death, instability, loss of honour, the cruel one ruling your life, destruction, and (without repentance) total ruin. Then verses 15-20 describe the fruit of a godly sexual relationship between a husband and wife: rejoicing, blessing, satisfaction, being enraptured or intoxicated with love. The benefits are many if we do it God's way.

In the world today, there are many sources from which we can learn about sex. Society is very eager to teach us its viewpoint about sex; our friends have their ideas; our parents probably taught us something; magazines and books on the subject are plentiful. The first source that we should go to is the Bible, after that we can refer to godly books on the subject.

Answer the following questions:

1. Where did you learn what you know about sex?

2. What influence do you feel has been the strongest in forming your attitude about sex? Do you consider it to be a godly influence? Why or why not?

3. What, if anything, did your parents tell you about sex?

4. As you anticipate marriage, what are your thoughts about sexual intercourse?

5. Do you have any concerns or apprehensions in the area of your sexual relationship with your future spouse?

There should be no shame connected with your sexual relationship after marriage. God intended for there to be openness as you communicate and express your feelings and desires. Genesis 3:25 says, "And they were both naked, the man and his wife, and were not ashamed."

Answer the following questions:

1.Do you believe it is important to discuss your sexual relationship with your partner? Why or why not?

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2. Do you feel comfortable in doing this or do you find it to be awkward and/or embarrassing? Why or why not?

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3. Have you expressed your feelings to your partner in the area of what you believe to be proper and improper sexual conduct and acts? What was your partner's response?

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As in every other area in our lives, we are to be a servant, so it is in the sexual relationship. Philippians 2:3,4 says, *"Let nothing be done through selfish ambition or conceit, but in lowliness of mind let each esteem others better than himself. Let each of you look out not only for his own interests, but also for the interests of others."* Your attitude in your sexual relationship should be, not what you can get out of it, but what you can put into it. Your goal is to bring total satisfaction (to the best of your ability) to your partner. 1 Corinthians 13:5 tells you that you are not to seek your own ways or demand your own rights. Love would not force someone to do something that would cause them shame. In your quest to bring fulfilment and satisfaction to your partner, you will need to be sensitive to what their needs are and how you can meet those needs. That takes honest communication and observation. Neither you nor your partner are mind-readers. Each of you needs to know what the other is thinking and feeling.

Answer the following questions:

1. Do you believe you understand the emotional needs of your partner and are able to meet them?

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_____

2. Ask your partner if he/she thinks you understand his/her needs. What was their response? If you have not talked about your emotional needs with your future spouse, now is a good time to start.

_____

_____

3. Have you felt:

any need to be better understood?

yes _____ no _____

any need for more warmth and closeness?

yes _____ no _____

any need for more tenderness?

yes _____ no _____

any blocks in expressing your own feelings?

yes _____ no _____

4. If you answered 'yes' to any of the above, what will you do to help remedy the situation? What has your partner said he/she will do to help?

5. Do you believe that the sexual relationship is limited to intercourse, or does it include more? Please explain.

Romance: acts of kindness, words of appreciation, non-sexual touching and praise is an important part of your relationship. Your sexual relationship does not start just when you hit the bed at night. If all you want to do is meet your physical need rather than purposing to meet the emotional and physical need of your future spouse, then you have reduced lovemaking to just merely a sex act. Give the affection that is due to your future spouse.

Explain, in your own words, what these scriptures mean to you:

I Corinthians 7:3-4

Proverbs 5:18-19

Hebrews 13:4

Song of Solomon 7:10

Answer the following questions:

1. Have you and your partner talked about children? (If you want any, how many, how soon, how far apart) Did you come to an agreement?

2. Have you talked about and come to an agreement on the use or non-use of contraceptives?

Marriage is ordained of God, and sex in marriage is God's gift to seal the marriage covenant and to bring blessing to the husband and wife.

Suggested reading: "The Act of Marriage" Tim & Beverly LaHaye

"Solomon on Sex" Joseph C. Dillow

"Intended for Pleasure" Ed Wheat